

IT TAKES TEAMWORK

“It takes two to tango,” said an older woman friend, at a wedding reception in France.

“It’s the only way a marriage can work. Each person has to dance. If one stops dancing, the other can’t continue. Sure, he can look for a new dance partner, but it’s not the same thing.

“There’s just so much to do. People today think only of making money and spending it. But there’s a lot more. You have to create a family. That’s different than just having children. Creating a family means creating family life. And that takes time. And it takes both husband and wife. The wife can’t be the husband too. The husband can’t be the wife, either.

“It takes two to tango. Two different steps . . . two different people . . . but dancing together. . . .”

Creating a “family life” in a household where the patriarch is focused on wealth creation is hard. It puts a strain on families. Building a fortune requires the vast majority of the husband’s (it could be the wife’s—we don’t care, but we’re going to use husband and wife in their most traditional and stereotypical form) energy. He may not be able to attend his children’s sporting events or help them with their homework. Instead, he’s got his own homework to do. It takes an extraordinary effort to produce extraordinary wealth. Ordinary people do ordinary things; they end up with ordinary money. Family money is unusual. It takes unusual efforts to get it and hold on to it. The energy that is put into work is often sacrificed at home.

That’s why it is almost impossible for a single dad or a single mom to create family money. It’s just too hard. If one spouse is going to focus on the money, the other has to focus on the family. There are, of course, exceptions. We know one wealth-building friend who is not at all in a conventional, traditional family. Instead, it’s a commune with its origins in the hippie communes of the 1960s.

More often, the husband focuses on the money. The wife focuses on the family. She, too, will have to make an exceptional effort; she, too, must do something extraordinary.

This is part of what a great matriarch does. She is to be a counterweight to the lightness of her husband in the home. She bears the responsibility of